



Anil Seth

Freeing the Mind

Sceptical of all graphical tools for analysis and design, this author stumbled onto Freemind – a discovery that led him to marvel at the benefits of mind maps. Read on to learn how he put it to good use.

I have never really been fond of graphical tools for analysis and design. We would write the code, and then create the flowcharts and the data flow diagrams, if they couldn't be avoided.

As a documentation aid, I find trying to understand an application using design or dataflow diagrams to be hard, even for moderately complex applications. I may even go to the extent of saying that I find it hard to understand class diagrams for anything larger than a design pattern. There are too many interconnections between the objects. I lose track and cannot focus on the desired subset. The connections from the subset of interest to the rest of the system are a serious distraction.

I was exploring Freemind with the intention of understanding what mind maps meant. The Wikipedia entry on Mind_map mentions that mind maps have a long history: "Some of the earliest examples of mind maps were developed by Porphyry of Tyros, a noted thinker of the 3rd century, as he graphically visualised the concept categories of Aristotle."

The ideas of mind mapping were fascinating, but my mind prefers text. While a picture may be worth a thousand words, it takes considerably fewer bytes to store a thousand words on the computer! The fact that I found mind maps useful came as a surprise even to me.

A basic mind map is a hierarchical representation of ideas—a tree. Each idea has a parent and multiple children. Thus, the interconnections are simple. One can focus on a part of the diagram with ease. It maps to the outline format of a text document.

I was required to create a job profile of the people reporting to me. The task was simple for programmers, team leads and project managers, but I hit a wall when it came to systems administrators! The bulleted list of the activities they were handling (or were supposed to handle) kept getting longer and more incoherent. Entering and organising these responsibilities in a mind map was very useful; it helped me organise and prioritise their roles. I was surprised how a simple visual representation of the same information made it easier for me to grasp the key features. I could then write a short, coherent job profile for the systems administrators.

Now, any time I have to analyse a document for

requirements, I use Freemind to create a mind map. I keep adding what would have been bullet points as nodes, and keep moving them around. I freely use notes for each node, to expand on the idea while keeping the mind map concise. Grouping clusters of nodes/ideas using clouds helps one focus better.

Finally, as a mind map is usually not an accepted format, I export it to an ODF document and polish it—essentially, properly format it and ensure that the text is grammatically correct. Even though only I see the mind map, my belief is that I am able to complete my task much faster thanks to Freemind. The quality of the document is better, and it's more concise than what I would have produced otherwise.

Another unusual use case was when I had to make a 20-minute presentation on something as large as J2EE. Freemind was invaluable in organising the possibilities, narrowing down the options and creating a presentation that would be useful

for the target audience, while keeping to the desired time-frame.

I am married, but if I weren't, I would even use Freemind to plan my wedding. The consequences of a bad start to a marriage are very long-term—just like it is for a software project!

As a developer, I would like to use a memory map, as it is critical to ensure that the specifications and their scope are well understood. As the owner of a project, I would love to get a memory map from the developers, so that I can quickly verify that their understanding of the project conforms to mine. The usual hundreds of pages of documentation are more useful to lawyers!

So, develop a memory map for each project, and share it—unless, of course, the company processes prevent the sharing! 

About Anil Seth

The author works as a consultant. Prior to consulting, Anil was a professor at Padre Conceicao College of Engineering (PCEE) in Goa; managed IT and imaging solutions for Phil Corporation Limited (Goa); supported domestic customers for Tata Burroughs/TIL; and was a researcher with IIT-K and Indian Institute of Geomagnetism (Mumbai). You can find him online at <http://sethanil.com> and reach him via email at anil@sethanil.com.